China's relations with India were regarded as secondary to engagement with the Soviets and the US. Tellingly, Chinese officials and experts are more likely to use the term 'skirmish' in referring to the 1962 war. If it was a skirmish rather than a full-blown war, why bother to write about it in detail? Western scholars who got access to the archives, too, were occupied with China and its relations principally with the US and paid little attention to archival materials on India.

At any rate, from what we do know, China had a rather similar internal debate in the early years. The Chinese scholar Dai Chaowu, who did access the archives, suggests that China, like India, was reluctant to broach the territorial issue. In conversation with Panikkar in September 1951, Zhou stated that 'there was no territorial dispute or controversy between India and China' and insisted that the borders could be stabilized through negotiations.[9] This may have been designed to lull Delhi into complacency, but it is quite plausible that the communists were genuinely uncertain of their own claim-lines and were playing for time in order to reach an internal consensus on how to proceed with India. For instance, in 1951, the senior Chinese jurist Zhou Gengsheng in the Ministry of Foreign Affairs delved into the 1914 Simla agreement between British Indian, Chinese, and Tibetan representatives. He concluded that China had accepted the draft convention but had refused to ratify the final version, and the boundary lines drawn, including the McMahon Line, were therefore illegal.[10]

By 1953, China had developed an understanding of its own position, at least in the eastern sector. Chinese officials in Tibet had by then submitted a report which outlined what became Beijing's view. In essence, the report drew attention to the Indian takeover of areas south of the mountain crest line in the North-East Frontier Agency (NEFA). It argued that China had claims south of the McMahon Line and that India should withdraw from those areas. It also argued that the line itself was based on imperial treaties and therefore illegitimate. The report concluded with the suggestion that China should open negotiations with India. This in effect was the Chinese 'sooner' school, which wanted to engage India early.[11]